Keyword research template: from a seed list to a keyword map

Eight parts: seed keywords from four sources, keyword scoring, a SERP overlap test, a keyword map, ICE priorities and a monthly cannibalization check. Fill it in by hand or in a PDF editor. Rows in italics are an example for a fictional accounting firm.

How to use this template

1. **Describe the business and the goal** (part 1): services, service area, language and what you do not sell.
2. **Collect seed keywords from four sources** (part 2). Just collect; do not judge yet.
3. **Add search volume, intent and current position** (part 3). No number available: write “no data”.
4. **Run the overlap test for pairs of keywords** (part 4) and group them into clusters.
5. **Give each cluster one target page and an action** (part 5).
6. **Set the order with ICE scores** (part 6).
7. **Check for cannibalization every month** (part 7). Before you close the map, go through the checklist in part 8.

Intent codes

I informational: a guide, definition or how-to

C commercial: comparisons, prices, reviews before deciding

T transactional: a specific offer, contact or purchase

L local: a business nearby, map pack in the results

N navigational: a specific business or website

Template rules

Overlap test: 4+ shared URLs out of 10 → one cluster; 2–3 → compare page types in the top 5 and repeat on another day; 0–1 → separate clusters.

One cluster = one page. Two pages chasing the same keywords weaken each other.

ICE: impact on leads × confidence × ease, each scored 1–10.

Quick wins: keywords in positions 4–20 in Search Console.

1. Overview and goal

The scope decides which keywords you drop straight away. Keywords outside your offer stay off the map, however many searches they get.

Business and website	
Services or products that matter most	
Service area (cities, regions, country) and language	
What we do not sell (keywords to drop)	
Goal: what search traffic should deliver (leads, sales, sign-ups)	
Date, completed by, review date	

2. Seed keywords from four sources

Write down everything that fits your offer. You score keywords in part 3. Each source sees a different slice of demand, so use all four.

Source	Where to look	Keywords
Search Console	Performance → Queries tab, sorted by impressions. Queries with impressions but no clicks, and positions 4–20. The table shows up to 1,000 rows: export the data on a large site.	
Customer questions	Sales, support, contact form, emails, phone calls. Write them down in the customers' own words.	
Google autocomplete	Suggestions and People also ask. Add to your service: cost, how, vs, for, a city name.	
Competitors and tools	3–5 competitors, Google Ads Keyword Planner (estimates), a paid tool (competitor keywords, difficulty).	

Remember: "no data" in Keyword Planner does not mean nobody searches. Keyword Planner hides very low-volume keywords. If a keyword keeps coming up in customer questions and autocomplete, keep it. Google Trends shows relative values on a 0–100 scale, not search counts.

3. Keyword list with scores

Read intent from Google's results, not from the wording. In "What ranks in the top 10", note the page types: service pages, guides, comparisons, shops, map pack, videos, AI Overview.

#	Keyword	Monthly searches and source	Intent	What ranks in the top 10	Position and URL (GSC)	Cluster
	accountant leeds	*number from Keyword Planner*	*L*	*map pack, firms' sites*	*pos. 9, /accounting*	*1*
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						

#	Keyword	Monthly searches and source	Intent	What ranks in the top 10	Position and URL (GSC)	Cluster
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						
21						
22						

4. SERP overlap test (clustering)

Compare the top 10 for two keywords in a private window, or in a tool with a fixed location, and count the shared URLs. Results change from day to day, so re-check the grey zone on another day. The 40–50% threshold is a working rule, not a figure published by Google.

Keyword A	Keyword B	Shared in top 10	Test date	Decision
accountant leeds	*accounting firm leeds*	*7 / 10*	*dd/mm*	*one cluster*
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check
		… / 10		☐ one cluster ☐ separate clusters ☐ re-check

5. Keyword map

One row = one cluster = one page. Put the primary keyword in the title, H1 and first paragraph; use secondary keywords in H2 headings and body copy where they fit. No stuffing.

#	Cluster	Primary keyword	Secondary keywords	Intent	Target page	Action	Priority
	Self-employed accounting	*accountant for self-employed*	*self-employed accountant, accounting for freelancers*	*T*	*/self-employed-accountant*	*new*	*high*
1						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
2						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
3						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
4						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
5						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
6						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
7						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
8						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
9						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	
10						☐ new ☐ expand ☐ merge ☐ keep	

6. ICE priorities

Impact = how many leads the cluster could bring (not how much traffic). Lower Confidence when you rely on one data source. Lower Ease when you need a developer. ICE = the product of the three scores; work from the highest score down.

#	Cluster	Impact (1–10)	Confidence (1–10)	Ease (1–10)	ICE	Order
	Self-employed accounting (illustrative scores)	*8*	*6*	*7*	*336*	*1*
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						

7. Cannibalization check (monthly)

Search Console → Performance → query filter with a keyword from the map → Pages tab. Two or more URLs with impressions for the same query: log them here. After publishing new content, wait a few weeks before deciding.

Query	URLs with impressions	Clicks / impressions	Decision	Owner and deadline
			☐ merge (301) ☐ separate intents ☐ change links ☐ canonical	
			☐ merge (301) ☐ separate intents ☐ change links ☐ canonical	
			☐ merge (301) ☐ separate intents ☐ change links ☐ canonical	
			☐ merge (301) ☐ separate intents ☐ change links ☐ canonical	

8. Keyword research checklist before you close the map

The map is ready when every item is ticked.

- ☐ Every keyword has a source for its search volume, or is marked “no data”
- ☐ The intent of every cluster has been checked in Google’s results
- ☐ Every cluster has exactly one target page
- ☐ No page is assigned to two clusters with the same intent
- ☐ Question keywords have a planned direct answer on the page (first paragraph under a question heading)
- ☐ High-priority clusters are in the SEO strategy and the content calendar
- ☐ Date of the first cannibalization check: _____

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